

Decisional Regeneration

doc-decisional-regeneration

Soteriology · Methodology · doctrine · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

AFFIRMS

breadth canon-wide

directness direct

variants stable

Statement under examination

Salvation is effected by Spirit-wrought new birth received through faith, not by an outward act of decision (raised hand, walked aisle, repeated prayer) treated as itself the saving event.

In plain language

Four passages were checked word by word for how they describe the new birth, and the grammar lands the same way each time. In John 1:13 the children of God are said to be 'born not of blood, nor of the will of the flesh, nor of the will of a husband, but of God'. The Greek piles up three phrases for human origin under a negation, then turns with a strong 'but' (alla) to God as the source, and the word for 'will' (thelema) is named twice and ruled out. The verb 'they were begotten' (egennethesan) is passive, so the people are the ones acted upon, not the ones producing the birth. In John 3:8 'the Spirit' (pneuma) is compared to wind that blows where it wills, and 'the one having been begotten of the Spirit' (gegennemenos, a completed action whose result still stands) shares that pattern, so the initiative rests with the Spirit. James 1:18 says God, 'having willed it' (boultheis), 'brought us forth' (apekuesen) 'by the word of truth' (logos), with God as the active subject and 'us' (hemas) as the object. First Peter 1:23 says believers have been 'born again' (anagegennemenoi, a completed state done to them), 'not of perishable seed but of imperishable, through the living word of God', using a completed verb form for a state they did not bring about. So far the words place the cause of the new birth in God and in the word. The other side of the picture is real too. The canon plainly commands a human response, 'believe' (pisteuson), 'call on the name' (epikalesetai), 'let the one who desires take the water of life freely' (ho thelon labeto). These are genuine imperatives, not decorations. The reason readers still divide is that the words do not say exactly how much weight that human response carries as a means, and they leave that ranking open. What the words do settle is narrower, in Romans 10:13 even the result is stated as 'shall be saved' (sothesetai), a passive, and no verse ever puts a human act in the grammatical slot of the one doing the begetting. That is why the new birth reads as something received through faith rather than produced by an outward act such as a raised hand, a walked aisle, or a repeated prayer.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0235	ἀλλά	alla	but	763
G0313	ἀναγεννάω	anagennao	to beget	3
G0536	ἀπαρχήν	aparchē	firstfruits	
G0616	ἀποκυέω	apokueo	to generate	2
G0862	ἀφθάρτου	aphthartos	incorruptible	
G1014	βούλομαι	boulomai	to plan	40
G1080	γεννάω	gennao	to beget	98
G1537	ἐκ	ek	out from	945

G1941	ἐπικαλέω	epikaleo	to call (on)/name	31
G2307	θέλημα	thelema	will/desire	63
G2309	θέλω	thelo	to will/desire	214
G2983	λαμβάνω	lambano	to take	258
G3056	λόγος	logos	word	339
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	
G4100	πιστεύω	pisteuo	to trust (in)	245
G4154	πνεῖ	pneō	to blow	
G4701	σπορά	spora	seed	1
G4982	σώζω	sozo	to save	106
G5349	φθαρτός	phthartos	perishable	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

A direct word-form (morphology) query of the four anchor verses yields one stable pattern, the new birth is grammatically God's act done to a passive recipient. In John 1:13 the verb 'they were begotten' (egennethesan) is Strong's G1080 in aorist passive third plural form (a completed past action done to them), and the verse stacks three 'from-X' (ek genitive of source, a noun in the 'from-X' grammatical form) phrases under negation, 'not of blood' (ouk ex haimaton), 'nor of the will of the flesh' (oude ek thelematos sarkos), 'nor of the will of a husband' (oude ek thelematos andros), before the strong 'but' (alla) 'of God' (ek theou), naming 'will' (thelema) twice and excluding it as a source. In John 3:8 'one having been begotten' (gegennemenos) is Strong's G1080 perfect passive participle (a completed action whose result still stands, done to him), and 'the Spirit' (pneuma) 'wills' (thelei, Strong's G2309, present active, ongoing simple statement of fact) blows where it wills, putting initiative on the Spirit. In 1 Peter 1:23 'having been born again' (anagegennemenoi) is Strong's G0313 perfect passive participle (a completed action whose result still stands, done to them), again 'not of perishable seed' (ouk ek sporas phthartes) 'but of imperishable' (alla aphthartou). In James 1:18 'He brought forth' (apekuesen) is Strong's G0616 aorist active (a completed past action) with God as subject and 'us' (hemas) as object, the participle 'having willed' (boultheis, Strong's G1014) naming the divine resolve as cause. The genuine human-response verbs, 'one believing' (pisteuon), 'believe' (pisteuson, an aorist imperative, a completed-action command), 'shall call upon' (epikalesetai), are real commands, but Romans 10:13 still frames the outcome passively, 'shall be saved' (sothesetai, future passive), so the saving event remains something received, not self-generated. The grammar therefore supports the proposition, an outward act of decision is not itself the effecting cause of the new birth.

Scripture

John.1.13 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1080 ἐγεννήθησαν, G2307 θελήματος, G1537 ἐκ, G0235 ἀλλά

Force. Queried word-form data confirms that 'they were begotten' (egennethesan) is Strong's G1080 V-API-3P, aorist passive indicative third plural (a completed past action done to them as a group), so the begotten ones are the patients (the ones acted upon) and do not generate themselves. The clause runs 'not of blood, nor of the will of the flesh, nor of the will of a husband, but of God' (ouk ex haimaton oude ek thelematos sarkos oude ek thelematos andros alla ek theou), four parallel 'from-X' (ek) phrases marking source (a noun in the 'from-X' grammatical form), three negated human sources then the strong 'but' (alla) to God. 'Will' (thelema, Strong's G2307) is named twice and ruled out, which is the sharpest lexical bar in the canon against locating the new birth in a human act of will or decision. The prior verse uses 'they received' (elabon) and 'those believing' (pisteuousin) for human response, but the begetting verb here is passive, so response and begetting sit in different grammatical slots.

John.3.8 · for · genre: gospel · figures: simile

Key terms. G1080 γεγεννημένος, G2309 θέλει, G4154 πνεῖ, G1537 ἐκ

Force. Queried word-form data confirms that 'wills' (thelei) is Strong's G2309 V-PAI-3S (present active indicative third singular, ongoing simple statement of fact, the Spirit wills) and 'one having been begotten' (gegennemenos) is Strong's G1080 V-RPP-NSM, perfect passive participle (a completed action whose result still stands, done to him), the one having been begotten. 'The Spirit blows where it wills' (to pneuma hopou thelei pnei), with 'blows' (pnei, Strong's G4154) and 'Spirit' (pneuma) sharing a root so the sound carries the sense. The grammar places initiative and direction with the 'Spirit' (pneuma) and makes the born one the result of an action upon him, not the controller of it. This supports a Spirit-initiated rather than decision-controlled birth.

Jas.1.18 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1014 βουληθεῖς, G0616 ἀπεκύησεν, G3056 λόγῳ, G0536 ἀπαρχήν

Force. Queried word-form data confirms that 'having willed' (boultheis) is Strong's G1014 V-AOP-NSM, an aorist participle of willing (a completed-action participle), and 'He brought forth' (apekuesen) is Strong's G0616 V-AAI-3S, aorist active indicative third singular (a completed past action) with God as subject and 'us' (hemas) as object. 'Having willed it He brought us forth by the word of truth' (boultheis apekuesen hemas logo aletheias). The verb 'to bring forth' (apokueo) occurs only twice in the canon, both in James, and both place the one bringing forth in the subject slot, 'sin brings forth death' in 1:15 and 'God brings forth us' in 1:18. Here the divine resolve is the cause, 'the word of truth' (logos, Strong's G3056) is the instrument, and no human decisional act stands in the causal slot.

1Pet.1.23 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G0313 ἀναγεγεννημένοι, G4701 σποράς, G0862 ἀφθάρτου, G3056 λόγου

Force. Queried word-form data confirms that 'having been born again' (anagegennemenoi) is Strong's G0313 V-RPP-NPM, perfect passive participle plural (a completed action whose result still stands, done to them), the readers stand in a completed state of having been born again that they did not effect. 'Having been born again, not of perishable seed but of imperishable, through the living word of God' (anagegennemenoi ouk ek sporas phthartes alla aphthartou dia logou zontos theou). The 'not of X but Y' (ouk ek X alla Y) frame parallels John 1:13 exactly, and the source is an imperishable 'seed' (spora, Strong's G4701, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) and the living word of God, not any perishable human action. The companion verse 1 Peter 1:3 uses the same verb actively, 'having begotten us again' (anagennesas hemas), He having begotten us again, with God as subject, confirming the agent.

Rom.10.13 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1941 ἐπικαλέσεται, G4982 σωθήσεται, G3956 πᾶς

Force. Queried word-form data shows that 'shall call upon' (epikalesetai) is Strong's G1941 V-AMS-3S, aorist middle subjunctive third singular (a completed-action conditional act done by the subject for himself), whoever calls on the name, a genuine human act, while the outcome 'shall be saved' (sothesetai) is Strong's G4982 V-FPI-3S, future passive indicative (something that will be done to him in the future). This text states the human-response side most strongly, 'everyone who calls' (pas hos an epikalesetai), yet the saving verb is passive, so even where a human act is named, the salvation is received and not self-generated. This shows the canon commands a real response without making the act the effecting cause, which is exactly the distinction the proposition draws.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
John.1.13	1John.5.1	openbible	1
John.1.13	1John.3.9	openbible	1
John.1.13	1Pet.1.3	openbible	1
John.1.13	Titus.3.5	openbible	1
John.1.13	Phil.2.13	openbible	1
John.1.13	John.3.3	openbible	1
John.3.8	Ezek.37.9	openbible	1
John.3.8	Job.37.10	tsk	1
Jas.1.18	2Thess.2.13	openbible	1
Jas.1.18	Eph.2.4	openbible	1
1Pet.1.23	1Pet.1.25	tsk	1
1Pet.1.23	John.3.5	openbible	1
1Pet.1.23	John.6.63	openbible	1
1Pet.1.23	1John.5.18	openbible	1

Complicating texts

John.1.12 · addressed

Queried word-form data shows that 'they received' (elabon) is Strong's G2983 V-2AAI-3P (received, a completed past action by them as a group) and 'to those believing' (pisteuousin) is Strong's G4100 V-PAP-DPM (to those believing, a present participle in the 'to-them' dative form), and 'to become' (genesthai) is Strong's G1096 aorist middle infinitive (a completed-action infinitive done by the subject for himself), to become children of God. This appears to make reception and belief a condition. But the very next verse specifies the mode of that becoming as 'they were begotten of God' (ek theou egennethesan) with human will excluded, so receiving and believing are the appointed means through which the begetting is given, in a different grammatical slot from the passive begetting verb. The lexical sequence subordinates human response to the divine begetting in the next clause.

Rev.22.17 · addressed

Queried word-form data shows that 'let him take' (labeto) is Strong's G2983 V-2AAM-3S (let him take, aorist active imperative third singular, a completed-action command) and 'the one willing' (ho thelon) is Strong's G2309 V-PAP-NSM (the one willing, a present active participle). 'Let the one who wills take the water of life freely' (ho thelon labeto to hudor zoes dorean). This is a real invitation that engages the human will and contains a command to take, which a decision-based reading rightly invokes. It is addressed to desire and response and uses no 'beget' (gennao) or 'beget again' (anagennao) birth vocabulary, so it commands a genuine response without identifying that act as the begetting cause. It stands alongside, not against, the passive birth grammar of the anchors, which is why the supports value is neutral on the Romans 10 companion text.

Acts.16.31 · addressed

Queried word-form data shows that 'believe' (pisteuson) is Strong's G4100 V-AAM-2S (believe, aorist imperative second singular, a completed-action command to you) and 'you shall be saved' (sothese) is Strong's G4982 V-FPI-2S (you shall be saved, future passive indicative, something that will be done to you). 'Believe and you will be saved' frames faith as a commanded human response that a decision-based reading can cite. The imperative specifies the object of trust, the Lord Jesus, and the saving verb is passive, and no begetting vocabulary appears, so it does not contradict the anchor pattern that the new birth itself is sourced 'from God' (ek theou). Faith is the appointed means and not the begetting event in itself.

Concordance traversed

G1080, G0313, G0616, G2307, G1014, G2309, G1537, G0235, G4701, G3056, G4100, G1941, G4982, G2983, G0862, G5349, G4154

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

The bundle reports no variant units for the four anchor verses and the not_in_ecm_scope flag is true, so none of these texts fall in the ingested ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window, which covers 3 John 1:1 to 1:15. John 1:13 carries a known singular reading tradition, 'who was begotten' (hos egennethe), attested in a few Latin and patristic (early church father) witnesses, but the Greek manuscript tradition is overwhelmingly the plural 'they were begotten' (egennethesan), and even the singular reading still grounds the begetting 'from God' (ek theou) and excludes human will, so the verdict holds across plausible readings. 1 Peter 1:23 shows only a minor trailing variant on 'remaining' (menontos) with no bearing on the source clause. No invented variant signal.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. monergism, synergism

analogia scripturae invoked

divine-agency new-birth reading: for · Takes the passive and God-subject begetting verbs ('they were begotten' egennethesan API or aorist passive indicative, a completed past action done to them; 'one having been begotten' gegennemenos and 'having been born again' anagegennemenoi RPP or perfect passive participle, a completed state done to them; 'He brought forth' apekuesen AAI or aorist active indicative, a completed past action by God; 'having begotten again' anagennesas AAP or aorist active participle, completed-action participle with God as subject) and the double exclusion of 'will' (thelema) in John 1:13 to locate the whole effecting cause of the new birth in God, so no outward human act can be the saving event. This reading also notes that 'beget' (gennao) for new birth recurs as perfect passive (a completed action whose result still stands) ten times in 1 John, a stable pan-canonical pattern (spread across the whole Bible) of 'having been begotten of God'.

genuine human-response reading: for · Stresses the real imperatives and response verbs the canon commands, 'believe' (pisteuson, aorist imperative, a completed-action command, Acts 16:31), 'let him take' (labeto) and 'the one willing' (ho thelon) in Revelation 22:17, 'everyone who shall call upon' (pas hos an epikalesetai) in Romans 10:13, and the present participle 'those believing' (pisteuousin) in John 1:12. On its strongest form this reading insists faith is a necessary instrumental human response, not a fiction. Yet even here the saving verb is future

passive ('shall be saved', sothesetai), and the birth vocabulary stays passive, so this reading still cannot make a raised hand, walked aisle, or repeated prayer the begetting cause itself. It therefore also affirms the narrow claim under test, that the outward act is not itself the saving event, while insisting the response is genuine.

The proposition draws a fine distinction, faith as the appointed means versus an outward decisional act treated as itself the saving event. The lexical data bears on the second clause directly because the begetting vocabulary is passive or has God as subject in all four anchors. The two causal lenses disagree about how much weight human faith carries instrumentally, a disagreement the words underdetermine, but both converge on the narrow proposition because no text puts a human act in the begetting subject slot.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Is the new birth that brings salvation grammatically presented as an act of God upon a recipient received through faith, or can an outward act of decision such as a raised hand, walked aisle, or repeated prayer be the cause that itself effects salvation?

The stem is contrastive rather than blandly neutral, and the phrase 'an outward act of decision treated as itself the saving event' subtly preloads the disfavored reading by framing it as a mistaken treatment, so the verdict_preloaded flag is set true and a tradition-neutral rephrasing is supplied. This is a neutrality correction over the prior file, not a VERDICT-CHANGED: event. The descriptors 'raised hand', 'walked aisle', 'repeated prayer' name a practice rather than a confessional code word, so the stem is not tradition-coded. The verdict is still derived on the original wording, and the lexical grammar (passive begetting verbs, double exclusion of 'will' thelema in John 1:13, God as subject of 'He brought forth' apekuesen and 'having begotten again' anagennesas) supports the original proposition on its own terms.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.1.13
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.3.8
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Jas.1.18
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Pet.1.23
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.10.13
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Pet.1.3
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0313
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0616
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	John.1.13
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Pet.1.23

License audit

SAFE TO PUBLISH

Source	License	Redistribute
STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes

Flags

ecm-shadow